

PART II: The Best Line of Transmission

Just what is Family 35?

I can well imagine that many of my readers are hearing about Family 35 for the first time. It refers to a line of transmission within the broad ‘Byzantine’ river of MSS, and I gave it that name. So far as I know, the academic world is severely ignoring my work, as they must, to be sure, since I expose the falsehoods they have been purveying for generations. I will begin with a bit of recent history.

When Thomas Nelson Inc. published my first book in 1977, *The Identity of the New Testament Text*, the best printed Greek New testament that was readily available was the *Textus Receptus*, the Received Text—it was the Greek Text of the Protestant Reformation. John William Burgon, Dean of Chichester, called it the ‘Traditional Text’. Although Zane C. Hodges and Arthur L. Farstad had started working on a Majority Text, based on the work of Hermann von Soden,¹ it was not published until 1982. In 1977 I demonstrated that the Westcott-Hort critical theory was false at every point, and that demonstration has never been refuted since, that I know of. But when it came to offering an alternative, I was limited to generalities and Burgon’s seven “Notes of Truth”.² Thomas Nelson put my book through at least three further printings, including some revision, the last one appearing in 1990. Even then, I had nothing better to offer.

However, in 1988 I helped to start the Majority Text Society, along with Zane Hodges, Art Farstad and Frank Carmichal, and was its first president. At that time I began to seriously work on Majority Text theory, and during the next decade developed what I was pleased to call Original Text theory. I used it as a steppingstone to my present approach to NT textual criticism (that we may call Family 35 Priority Theory). Here it is:

1. First, OTT is concerned to identify the precise original wording of the NT writings.³

¹ *Die Schriften des Neuen Testaments in ihrer ältesten erreichbaren Textgestalt* (Teil 1, Berlin: Verlag von Alexander Duncker, 1902-1910; Teil 2 Göttingen: Vandenhoeck und Ruprecht, 1913).

² They are: 1. Antiquity, or Primitiveness; 2. Consent of Witnesses, or Number; 3. Variety of Evidence, or Catholicity; 4. Respectability of Witnesses, or Weight; 5. Continuity, or Unbroken Tradition; 6. Evidence of the Entire Passage, or Context; 7. Internal Considerations, or Reasonableness. Burgon, *The Traditional Text*, p. 29.

³ Here I reject the allegation that the original wording is lost and gone.